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In just a matter of a few weeks we'll move into a new year. For those of us in the world of education, it traditionally marks the halfway point of the school year. Though everyone else has their minds on starting from scratch, we're in the thick of things. For many forensic coaches, now is the time of year when you address what's working with your team and what exactly isn't.

A little introspection never hurt anyone.

Challenge your students to pick up the pace as we move down the stretch toward state tournaments, qualifiers, and (they'll be here before you know it) Nationals. The first semester doesn't really matter any more. Come January, you'll be rested and ready to go.

Okay, maybe the sense of renewal the new year brings isn't really all that different between forensicators and the real world.

That could very well be a first.

Best of luck as your season continues! It is my that 2007 is filled with fun adventure for both you and your program.

Corey Alderdice
Publisher

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Thrift

by Daschle Stephens

Humiliation has always played an integral part in self-discovery, and I suppose my life is no different. In my high school Intro to Drama class – we had to go around the room and introduce ourselves by telling everyone what animal we were most like. The other guys were panthers. They were grizzlies, lions, eagles, and boa constrictors – they were beasts of power, strength, and virility. Me? I was a squirrel. So while every other turbo-testosterone charged teen male was on the prowl – I was left open to a barrage of hi-larious innuendos about my "nuts". It never got old.

Now in my own defense, the squirrel thing isn't as asinine as it may sound. Growing up, money was tight around my house. We were by no means starving, but we had a healthy appreciation for what we had. Much like squirrels, my younger brother, Kevin, and I were always on the lookout to gather resources for home. If we were good during the week, my mom would take the two of us out to McDonald's for a family dinner on Friday. After finishing our Happy Meals, my brother and I would make sure to grab extra salt, pepper, and packets of "fancy ketchup" to take home for future dinners. At age 8 this ritual is charming and endearing. At age 28 you're called cheap by merciless friends and coworkers – to which I always respond, "Back off – my meatloaf is now delicious *and* fancy."

Sundays were always spent diving through the paper for the coupons and sale sections. Eventually my brother and I would create games to make the task of bargain hunting for mom a little more enjoyable. Sometimes we would compare products at different stores to see who had the best deals, and to make the stakes more interesting: the one with the lower price gave the other an Indian Sunburn or during the holidays – a delightful Texas Tittie Twister. Scissors askew - we flew like starving junkyard dogs through the sections. Kevin had an eye for office supplies and clothing sales but I always delivered a weekly whooping when it came to frozen foods and produce. Working two jobs to make ends meet, my mom appreciated the help though she never really saw the need to spend money on the frivolous things that kids find to be the most important. Case in point – neither Kevin nor I ever had a real lunchbox. And by real, I do mean the plastic box with a cartoon or action hero on the front. Mom figured that the plastic bags that we brought home our groceries in worked just fine. This never really bothered me, but it always seemed to irritate the other kids at school who felt the need to show off: A). The lunchboxes that their parents bought them and B). The unforgiving physics the thin bag had on my chips when met with someone's balled up fist before walking to the bathroom.

It was at this point that I usually emptied the contents of a packet of "fancy ketchup" into one of their open cans of Dr. Pepper. The projectile vomiting that followed would ensure the safety of my chips in the future. But this didn't stop my mom from trying to stencil Optimus Prime on my grocery bag the next day out of guilt.

*

If being thrifty made me the weird kid – it has also made me an awkward adult. As I move grudgingly through the end of my 20's, I still have the charm of Beaver Cleaver in the throes of puberty. My hair cowlicks in angles not found in advanced geometry classes, my clothes are so far from being name brand that the tags are blank, I can never find anything witty to say and I laugh like Pee-Wee Herman. Ladies…control yourselves. One good thing to come of my money conscious upbringing was the ability to crunch numbers freakishly well resulting in a passion for mathematics and yet another way to drive away the opposite sex. These days I work as a computer programmer at a faceless corporation. Sure, there are the same predator archetypes in the work place as there were in high school – but for every squirrel there are a dozen lions and panthers ready to bust my bushy behind into submission. There's a reason why you don't see many squirrels

Schrodinger's Kiss

by Bonnie Minkey

SCENE 1 -- (*Beth and Greg are on the phone*)

BETH. So…I have this lamp here with like flowers and stuff on it. It's my parents' but they said I could bring it if I wanted it—

GREG. Yeah, bring it, we could use some more light in here.

BETH. But I mean, it's pretty ugly—it's that dark reddish-orange hippy color with yellow flowers. I mean—no, I'm not gonna bring it—

GREG. Okay, sweet pea.

BETH. Also—do you have a blender? Do we even need a blender?

GREG. I don't have one…and…I don't know…what is there to blend again?

BETH. Okay, I'm leaving the blender.

GREG. Right then, no blending. But maybe bring the lamp. There are plenty things to lamp.

BETH. You mean to light.

GREG. I mean to light. You're so clever.

BETH. Okay then I guess I'll see you tomorrow, locked and loaded…and ready to unload.

GREG. I'm nervous about meeting your parents in person.

BETH. Don't be, they'll be really nice to you. They won't talk about how you're totally unworthy of me until they're sure you can't hear them.

GREG. Oh, good.

SCENE 2 -- (*In the apartment*)

BOTH. Bye! (*waving to departing parents*)

BETH. Thanks for everything!

GREG. Bye.

BETH. Whooo. Always a challenge.

GREG. They seemed great.

BETH. They are. Good job being an upstanding boyfriend in their presence.

GREG. I'm not otherwise?

BETH. You are…but you definitely turned it on for them. Which was a good plan. I mean—

GREG. (*Not terribly interested, he cuts her off)* Hey—I've been waiting to show you this—Okay, there's this is really interesting…project…experiment…thing—I picked up this ad from the psych department the other day. Alright, I'm just gonna read it, hold on—(*He gets it off of a table.)*

BETH. Okay?

GREG. Okay: "Romantic Roomies! Planning on moving in with your significant other within the next year? (*He makes a face at her).* Dr. Salisbury and her professional team are offering $1,000 for your participation in a study of this important transitional period. Call for details."

BETH. What is this?

GREG. Well I called—I mean….

BETH. Yeah, a thousand bucks.

GREG. Yeah. I like the way you think, missy.

BETH. Well tell me what's up.

GREG. Well I guess they want to observe what couples go through when they start living together. Alright, I'm looking at the website right now. The deal is you put a video camera in your "main living area" and just…leave it on for a month.

BETH. Is this some elaborate scheme to get porn?

GREG. (*Laughs)* No, It's Dr. Salisbury on campus. She writes all kinds of stuff about how people and animals react to sharing space. Space

Sharing. It's her thing.

BETH. I mean, it looks legitimate, I guess.

GREG. Yeah, and like a very easy way to make some money. Let's look at the details—there's a website. (*He calls it up on the computer*)

BETH. Yeah...yeah, there's that. We could spend it on our apartment!

GREG. Or just split it down the middle.

BETH. That's not very romantic.

GREG. Is any of it?

BETH. Maybe! I kind of like the idea of recording our first month. Don't you?

GREG. Yeah—I just imagine most of it won't quite be...HBO quality.

BETH. I dunno, I think we'll put on a pretty good show.

GREG. Whoa—no show. She's VERY clear about how the "subjects" are to carry on as if the camera is not there—see? (*gesturing toward the screen*) "...it's critical the subjects work to ignore the presence of the camera."

BETH. Yeah, I get that. "The Subjects." So do we lab rats get to keep a copy?

GREG. I imagine we could. But seriously—it can't be a performance.

BETH. I know! But I still think we should get a copy. You can edit it!

GREG. Mmm hmm. Uh-oh. (*looking at website*). Looks like...we have to start immediately—to "capture the initial stages of Space Sharing" and all—so if we're gonna do this I have to get the camera...I guess today.

BETH. And you get it directly from Dr. Salisbury or whoever?

GREG. Yeah, I think so.

BETH. And then we get a thousand bucks.

GREG. Well in a month, yeah.

BETH. For sticking a camera on the wall.

GREG. Yep.

BETH. Well, I'm in.

GREG. (*In a baby voice*) You're such a good girl.

BETH. Aw.

SCENE 3 -- (*Two hours later. In the living room.*)

GREG. (*Screwing the camera into the wall*) Okay, now walk around...and...it...should follow you.

BETH. Just walk around?

GREG. Yeah. All around the room.

BETH. (*She does so hesitantly*)

GREG. Okay, that's it. (*Joins her looking up at it*) How is it?

BETH. Well. It's like...I'm being observed in my living room.

GREG. Ah, yes, just like that. (*They stare at it. Beth looks around as if to check if anyone is watching, then sticks her tongue out quickly. Greg laughs, makes a face. They run around in front of it, becoming increasingly boisterous and ridiculous in front of the camera, until they are hysterical and tired.*)

BETH. Okay, okay, we have to stop. Aren't we supposed to act normal?

GREG. Yeah, or we don't get paid.

BETH. Right. (*Sticks her tongue out at it again*)

GREG. No, really, this is serious, we have to be serious.

BETH. Right. (*Sticks her tongue out seriously*)

GREG. Really, Beth, we have to act like it's not here.

BETH. I know, I'm sorry, I got it under control now.

GREG. (*A little patronizingly)* You better.

BETH. (*A little hurt*) Okay, okay, I know.

SCENE 4 -- (*Three hours later, snuggling on the couch.*)

GREG. So you're unpacked.

BETH. I'm unpacked.

GREG. I'm so glad you're here.

BETH. I'm so glad to be here.

GREG. (*Sweet talk style*) You're so precious.

BETH. You're so precious.

GREG. You're so perfect.

BETH. You're so...(*feeling awkward suddenly, perhaps aware of the camera*) silly. I feel silly.

GREG. Why?

BETH. No reason, never mind.

GREG. What's up?

BETH. Nothing. Where were we?

GREG. I was telling you what a cutie you were, you cute little thing.

BETH. I—Matt, I don't like that.

GREG. What?

BETH. I hate to ruin the moment, but "cute little thing" just doesn't work for me...anymore.

GREG. Any more? What are you talking about? I've called you that a million times—C'mere— you ARE my cute little thing...

BETH. Matt! It just feels...it makes me feel...small. And "thing." Thing is so...thingy. I mean—I'm a person.

GREG. Beth, I KNOW you're a person. I didn't mean it that way. I didn't mean it to make you feel weird at all. I was just trying to be cute.

BETH. I know, I know. It's just—it struck me differently just now. Like I heard it for the first time—and I just didn't like it, okay?

GREG. Okay, Beth, whatever—I mean, I'll say, er, I WON'T say whatever you...don't want.

BETH. Thanks.

GREG. You're welcome.

BETH. You're so perfect.

GREG. You're so precious...

SCENE 5 -- (*A week later, making adjustments.*)

GREG. (*They wrestle with a big chair.*) Okay, okay, almost got it.

BETH. This thing smells funny.

GREG. Like incense funny or stinky funny?

BETH. "Stinky funny!" That's funny. Stinky.

GREG. Me?

BETH. The chair.

GREG. That's so embarrassing. I can't believe you said that with (*he glances at camera*)—

BETH. Hey. None of that (*referencing the camera*). And you need to chill out. At least it LOOKS good (*the chair*). You know, I think we should move the couch over herel.

GREG. (*Gruffly*) It's good where it is.

BETH. No really, then we could put the coffee table in front of it and this side of the room could be freed up a bit.

GREG. For what?

BETH. I dunno, dancing or...playing...twister.

GREG. Performing?

BETH. What are you talking about?

GREG. (*Slowly, patronizingly*) I like the couch where it is.

BETH. But it's against the window—we could let a lot more light in and—

GREG. Look, this whole last week you have wanted to reorder everything in this place. I mean, I let you in here and you want to take it over and turn everything upside down!

BETH. "Let me in?" "LET ME IN?" If that's how you feel then maybe I need to let myself out! Or do I need to ask to be "LET OUT?"

GREG. Beth, can I have a word with you in the kitchen?

BETH. Greg, this is ridiculous, we can't relocate our argument just because you're afraid to look mean on camera!

GREG. I'm mean?!

BETH. You "let me in" your apartment—do you know how that makes me feel?

GREG. Well it's just you want to change everything and I LIKED how things were in here. Isn't anything okay where it was where I put it?

BETH. We left the painting!

GREG. (*Incredulously*) The one behind the toilet?

BETH. It's just I think I have an eye for this stuff, and also, (*loudly*) it's *important* that we *recreate* this place so it feels like it's ours and not just yours that I happen to be living in!

GREG. Oh, I'm sure Dr. Salisbury will love that. Very academic observation. PERFECT for her research.

BETH. I'm serious—If we're going to be equals here, I have to claim the space in my own ways!

GREG. (*He leans into the living room*) Are you GETTING THAT, DR. Salisbury?

BETH. I'm telling YOU.

GREG. Then why did you raise your volume on that particular thought?

BETH. I'm not the one yelling!

GREG. Beth, are you talking to me or to the camera?

BETH. Are you hiding from me or from the camera?

GREG. I don't know.

BETH. I don't either.

GREG. It's just you used to be so sweet and simple, and now you fight with me all the time.

BETH. Sweet and simple, that's exactly right. I just wanted to please you all the time, so of course you were happy. But then somehow I started seeing myself more clearly and I—

GREG. Somehow?

BETH. Yeah, somehow, maybe the camera, sure, it doesn't matter how, but whatever it is, it seems very clear that I've been letting you push me around our entire relationship...

GREG. Push you around?

BETH. Yes, in subtle ways, in little, verbal ways. The way you talk to me sometimes—I feel like you try to boss me around, or make me feel...younger or something. Greg, I don't want to be your "cute little thing." I can't be that anymore. I don't see myself that way anymore.

GREG. It's all because of the camera.

BETH. (*She doesn't know what to say*)

GREG. It's all because of the stupid camera—we never should have signed up for this. It CHANGED EVERYTHING (*to camera*); it RUINED EVERYTHING!

BETH. (*Overlapping above*) Greg, stop! Stop. Maybe it needed to be ruined. It needed to change. (*She pauses to collect her thoughts*) I needed to change. I needed to grow up. (*Beat*) Matt, you need to change too. And I think you can see it too. (*Definitively*) You can can't you.

GREG. (*He thinks for a long time, lets go of tension, looks up at her*). Beth, I'm sorry. (*They look at each other. They understand each other*).

BETH. (*Hopefully*) Okay.

GREG. Should we take it down?

BETH. Do we need to?

GREG. I don't know. Maybe not. The money would be nice.

BETH. It would.

GREG. You feel up to moving that couch?

BETH. I think it's really going to open up the space in there.

GREG. I think you're right. You ready?

BETH. Yeah. You?

GREG. Yeah.